

Tuck Business Bridge Program
Business Communication Syllabus
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Everything we do in Business Communication (BusComm) is designed to set you up for a strong capstone presentation on the final day of Bridge, while emphasizing business communication fundamentals. Many of you are already experienced communicators; this course will help you tailor your experience for a business audience.

Over four class sessions and an Executive Summary Lab, you will refine your skills in planning, structuring, and delivering a presentation with clarity and confidence. Each session builds on the prior one and all class activities connect directly to your capstone presentation. You'll be working with your project team during portions of each class. During our time together, we'll focus on these areas:

- Class 1: Planning for your Bridge Project
- Class 2: Developing your Executive Summary through Storyboarding
- Executive Summary Lab: Creating a Narrative for your Presentation
- Class 3: Designing a Persuasive Presentation
- Class 4: Delivering an Engaging Presentation

CLASS 1: Planning for your Bridge Presentation

Learning Objectives:

- Understand your primary audience and identify the key question they will expect you to answer during your Bridge capstone presentation
- Develop a high-level Issue Tree for the project that will frame your presentation

Preparation for Class:

1. Watch the *Welcome to BusComm* video
2. Come to class prepared to answer:
 - Who is your client/audience and what question are they asking you to answer?
 - What do you want your client/audience to do based on the information you present?
3. Review the *Capstone Presentation Examples* on Canvas with an eye toward how they are structured.
 - What do you see? What is the 'skeleton' structure that they all have?
 - What questions do you have about the presentations?

CLASS 2: Developing your Executive Summary through Storyboarding

Learning Objectives:

- Identify structure and message techniques that build from basic neuroscience principles and help your audience hear and understand your message
- Begin drafting the Executive Summary storyline for your capstone presentation, identifying the connections between your value drivers and valuation
- Review the storyboarding process and understand how to build a strong narrative across your presentation through Horizontal and Vertical Logic

Preparation for Class:

There is no formal preparation for class today. Today's session will be a workshop where you'll work with your team to develop the Executive Summary storyline for your capstone presentation, with an eye towards connecting the storyline and valuation. Be ready to step back from the research you've done to date and think about the major value drivers for your target company.

After Class

Complete the draft of your Executive Summary that you started in class, and be prepared to share it with your Professor during the Executive Summary Lab.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY LAB: Creating a Narrative for your Presentation

Learning Objectives:

- Receive feedback on your team's draft Executive Summary
- Ask any questions you have about your working hypothesis, including the arc of the story, the logic of your value drivers, and the evidence that supports the story

You and your team will be meeting with your BusComm professor on Zoom for 20 minutes to pressure test your Executive Summary.

Bring the latest draft of your ExecSum and be ready to share the slide via Zoom. I'll read through it and ask you questions, providing feedback and suggestions.

Preparation for the Lab:

- Complete the draft Executive Summary you started in BusComm Class #2 (template available on Canvas).
- Be ready to share your Executive Summary via Zoom.
- Assess your ExecSum using the following checklist to help guide your efforts:
 - Does the headline clearly state the share price, and is it limited to two lines (BLUF)?
 - Are the headers of the four sections written in declarative, parallel language?
 - Does the first value driver provide market context and illustrate the forecasted (baseline) industry growth?
 - Are the second and third value drivers the most important topics, informing your valuation?
 - Does the valuation section include your team's major assumptions and a comparison to the current market price?
 - Does the bullet point evidence for each value driver tell a story and support the header?

After the Lab

Look at your Executive Summary with a 'fresh' set of eyes. Continue to revisit and refine your ExecSum based on new information and research.

Once you are satisfied with your Executive Summary, begin to create the content slides for each 'chapter' of your presentation. Balance your company-focused data with an external perspective (industry data and competitors). Consider how each chapter informs the baseline assumptions in your valuation model (e.g. revenue, cost, etc.)

CLASS 3: Creating a Persuasive Presentation

Learning Objectives:

- Understand how slide design decisions, including Vertical Logic, can improve visual clarity and make it easy for the audience to digest visual content
- Consider diagram and chart options to share evidence in support of the presentation's narrative

Preparation for Class:

After refining your Executive Summary, build out your storyboard.

- Draft the slide headlines for the entire presentation. Use Horizontal Logic, introduced in BusComm Class #2, to ensure that each headline makes standalone sense and, when read in sequence, that the headlines tell a story.
- Begin to sketch out how you will display the data (evidence) that supports the slide headlines.
- For an overview of some visual basic principles and slide design ideas:
 - Watch: Video: *Creating Slide Content* (~23 min) -- you'll see lots of Bridge examples displaying quantitative and qualitative information. Key topics / time stamps within the video:
 - Template selection & core slide design decisions (starts at ~2:00)
 - Data display options
 - Qualitative diagrams (stats at ~7:00)
 - Images (starts at ~10:00)
 - Charts (starts at ~12:00)
 - Valuation section slides (starts at ~17:30)
 - Chart hygiene, avoiding visual clutter, and navigation (starts at ~20:00)
 - PowerPoint slides from the video are also available

In class, we'll review some slide examples that demonstrate effective and less effective use of visuals to tell a story. In addition, we'll provide time for you and your team to workshop your current slides and get feedback.

After Class:

Continue to refine your team's Executive Summary and supporting slides. The following resources on Canvas may be helpful as you refine your presentation:

- Check out the **Qualitative** and **Quantitative Insights** handouts for slide layout ideas. The tips and considerations in these handouts will help you identify the best visuals for your data.
- Review the *Capstone Presentation Examples* a second time, with an eye toward finding good design ideas and examples of how teams used their visuals to support their story

CLASS 4: Delivering an Engaging Presentation

Learning Objectives:

- Practice your presentation delivery skills, both verbal and non-verbal, and tailor your style for a business audience
- Present content-rich PowerPoint visuals using an effective structure
- Prepare for Q&A, including best practices and anticipating potential questions

Preparation for Class:

Today's session will be a workshop where you'll practice presentation delivery skills, including presenting with slides and anticipating audience questions. Be ready to engage in a series of interactive exercises, including presenting in small groups.

1. Watch **Presenting with Visuals/HOP-T**. This video covers the HOP-T technique (including examples from Bridge capstone presentations) and outlines some best practices when you're presenting with slides. You will practice presenting with HOP-T in class.
2. Select content: before class, select the slide loop that you would like to use for presenting practice in class. Your options are:
 - Pick one of the **four (4) slide loops available in Canvas**
 - Use 3 slides from your own capstone presentation (these should be sequential slides with strong Horizontal Logic)
3. Prepare to present your selected slides using HOP-T
 - Spend some time reviewing your slide loop and get familiar with the storyline and how the slides fit together.
 - Download your selected slides to your laptop before class.

In class, you will work with your selected slides to practice presenting.

After Class

For more resources and information on presentation delivery:

- Read the PDF entitled *Engaging your Audience through Delivery & Structure*
- Review some **Tips and Tricks for Managing Anxiety** if you would like some techniques for handling nerves when presenting.
- If you would like more guidance on HOP-T, including examples of HOP-T utilized by a range of presenters and in diverse situations, there are individual videos covering **each component of HOP-T** available in Canvas.
- **Topical Communication Resources:** If you're interested in exploring more communication topics, there is a list of optional resources (books, videos, and

articles) available on Canvas, covering themes including delivery, structure, storytelling, feedback, visuals, and use of AI tools for communication.

Review the *Presentation Checklist* on Canvas and keep it as a handy reference for this, and future presentations!